

The Challenges of Ground Combat

No corner of the war zone was entirely safe in Vietnam, and no role was without risk, but some places and duties were more dangerous than others. Army and Marine Corps infantry—the ground troops—suffered most of the casualties.

◀◀ BEFORE

The hardships of ground combat in Vietnam were similar to those experienced in previous wars.

IN THEIR FOOTSTEPS

The **hunger, exhaustion, fear, and loneliness** endured by foot soldiers in Vietnam would have been familiar to veterans of **World War II, Korea, the American Civil War**, and conflicts long before that. However, infantry in Vietnam tended to see more war than their counterparts in earlier conflicts—an average of 240 days, compared to just 40 days for infantrymen in World War II. The fact that individuals in Vietnam **served for a fixed term** and knew exactly when their tour of duty would end often turned the war into personal struggles for survival.

Between moments of violence and terror, American ground troops faced many physical hardships, especially out in the bush. On patrols that might last hours, days, or even weeks, they “humped” through difficult terrain, hacking trails through lacerating elephant grass and vicious thorns. Vietnam’s climate exacerbated soldiers’ discomfort, guaranteeing oppressive heat and humidity most of the year, but also drenching rain at temperatures cool enough to cause hypothermia at higher elevations, such as in the Central Highlands.

There was also the weight. An infantryman’s kit was easily 100 lbs (45 kg) or more. Fighting gear might consist of a web belt with ammunition pouches, hand grenades, smoke grenades, first-aid kit, and canteen. Packs contained a poncho and liner, extra socks and clothes, a gun-cleaning kit, and C-rations—cans of meat or chopped ham and eggs, cans of fruit, and pound cake. There might also be small luxuries such as candy, cameras, and cigarettes. Soldiers with particular functions would also pack mines, a specialist radio, or other equipment, and all of them would carry as much weaponry as possible: extra grenades, a spare rifle bolt, sometimes a handgun, and usually a knife. A rifle, helmet, and flak jacket rounded out the kit. The gear was so heavy that soldiers often discarded items on the march to lighten the load.

Friend or foe?

Frustration was perhaps the infantrymen’s primary state of mind—frustration caused by all the physical discomforts, but also because of the confusing cultural and political climate in which they fought. The US Army and Marine Corps infantry are trained for combat, and they generally excelled in this role in Vietnam, but they were not prepared for the uncertainties of this particular combat zone. While North Vietnamese regulars were easy to identify, the insurgents were often indistinguishable from the civilian population of South Vietnam. Soldiers frequently described villagers as duplicitous, smiling and selling sodas to them during the day, then facilitating Viet Cong sabotage and sniping at night. The language barrier—most American soldiers knew only a few phrases of pidgin Vietnamese—and racial and cultural prejudices exacerbated tensions between South Vietnamese villagers and exhausted American infantrymen.

Psychological impact